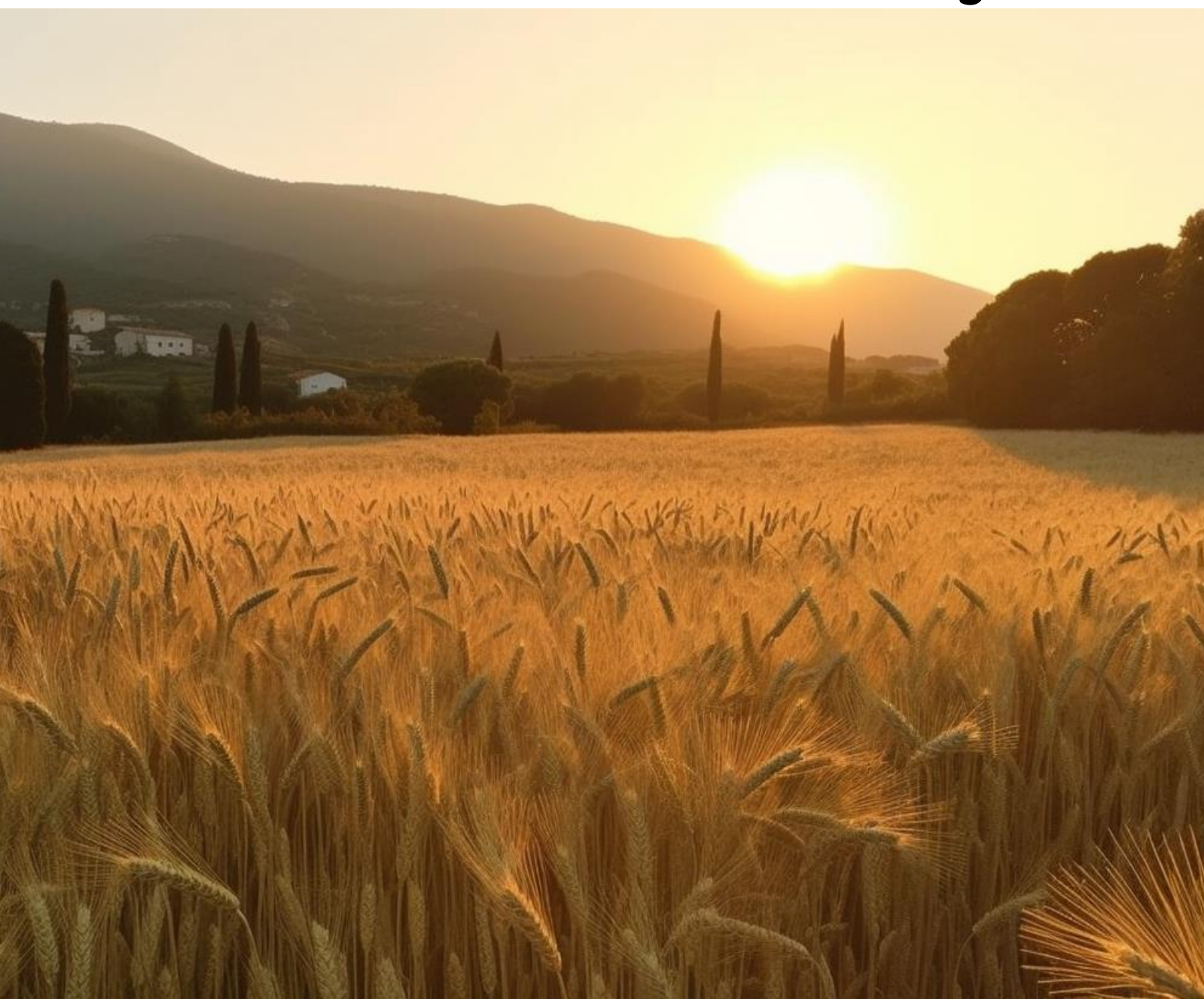


KORANTINE RITES

Designing a quasi-ancient society for Mythras and other RPGs

by Jonathan Drake

Part IV: Adventures in Farming



When your Adventurers have had enough of spending their treasure on good living and shiny new armour, they will have to decide what to do with their leftover cash. Banking is in its infancy, there's no way to easily put your money on deposit unless you have devised a trustworthy organisation for your setting to fill this role. You can put it in a strongroom perhaps, if you have one, and hope for the best. If things are especially uncertain, you might just bury it in a secret spot in the hope that you, rather than some future archaeologist or metal detectorist, will be the one to dig it up again when things settle down. You could find someone who needs the cash and is willing to take a loan, hoping you will get it all back again with a bit of interest. Or you can invest your money in the expectation of future growth.

The natural thing to do with idle cash in a quasi-ancient world is to take 'future growth' quite literally and invest in land. Once it's yours, land cannot be easily stolen from you, and it retains its value if you look after it, and you can often increase its value by making improvements. Land is a visible asset, so in a world where wealth brings status and recognition people will know your worth without you having to deck yourself out in gaudy jewels. Even though there are affluent people who don't own land but instead have a trade or own a business, real estate remains the default yardstick by which wealth is measured. For this reason a grant of land is regarded as one of the best rewards that a grateful city or a wealthy patron can give in thanks for a service. You may get a small peasant farm for fighting in a war on behalf of your city, and you might get a huge estate if you have been instrumental in the defeat or conquest of an enemy – usually taken from that same defeated enemy. But most of all, if there is someone who can put the necessary labour into it, a farm can generate food and income every year. It is also the preferred collateral on

any cash loan you may need to take out to fund your further adventures.

A city's territory is its most vital resource because the people depend on it for their living, and owning even a small patch of it shows you belong and have a stake in the city's wellbeing. It is normal to deny the right to own land in a city's domain to anyone who is not a local citizen, and to deny the full rights of citizenship to those who don't have any. It can be a high honour to make an exception to the rule for a foreigner. Naturally, if the foreigner is a citizen of a conquering empire, all the rules can be relaxed...

Growing Stuff and Feeding People

The primary purpose of owning land is usually to try to grow food on it, and in a quasi-ancient setting the staple food is always some form of grain. A farmer needs about 135kg of seed to get the maximum harvest out of a hectare of arable land. This represents an investment of about 20SP to buy the seed. The hope is to harvest 6 times or more the amount planted. So if everything works out, after setting aside enough of the harvest for the next planting there will be perhaps 650-700kg, worth about 100SP, left over¹. Whether that's wheat or barley, it delivers about 3,400 calories per kilo. Using an allowance of 240kg to feed each adult for a year, the output of a single Hectare will feed a farmer and his wife, with almost 200kg left to support a child, store up for a bad year, or sell on the market to raise a bit of cash (about 30SP) and maybe buy something to alleviate the monotony of a diet of bread and gruel.

If you are a tenant farmer perhaps more than half that bit of surplus is owed to your landlord. This is not a very promising existence. A second hectare would really improve things and is really the smallest functional plot for a family who rely on farming to cover all their needs. The good news is that one or two hectares of

¹ This is necessarily providing some exact-looking figures to some very inexact real-life data,

especially where estimating ancient seed to harvest ratios are concerned!

land won't require anything like all your labour for the year, there's only so much you can do. So if there is work available, our farmers can certainly make use of their skills and labour to add to their income.

Fallow Fields

Unfortunately for those who have little land to work with you may need to rest your fields between crops to restore the soil nutrients, otherwise the yields you get will gradually dwindle. Perhaps this is a good problem for magic to tackle – otherwise the only way to speed things up is by spreading manure, but very few people have sufficient grazing animals close to hand to furnish enough of the stuff. Resting your fields means you either need to plant something different for a year, which won't deliver the same kind of quantities of food staple, or you might leave a field totally unused (bare fallow), not generating any food for the family or produce for market. The dent in what you can produce when leaving fields fallow means that poor people without much land are inevitably going to cheat, and skip the fallowing. If you do that year after year it could end in ever-decreasing yields and ultimately in disaster.

Life-Giving Rain

Should you be prepared to take on the challenge of making a living from the soil, life may be about to get tough. Anyone setting out to put their skills, knowledge and the strength of their bodies into a battle for survival knows that, however hard they try, the Gods may strike down their every effort. In a quasi-ancient society the weather-god reigns supreme because the rains are a matter of life and death.

Back in the Bronze Age, the stand-out civilisations were found in river valleys and flood plains where they can irrigate their crops in an otherwise very dry region. But now, in the Iron Age, those river-cultures can be as much prisoner to the river valleys as they are nourished by them. The stand-out civilisations

are ones that trust to rainfall to bring life to their crops. The rains can be fickle, but people are adaptable. They have more technologies available to them – especially in metalworking and seafaring. If need be they can be mobile, acquisitive, innovative and often aggressive in pursuit of prosperity.

A quasi-ancient society takes its inspiration from real world analogues where the warm and arid conditions of the Mediterranean region are the norm. Some areas enjoy much higher rainfall because of very specific local conditions – and these areas can be highly prized and often fought over. The practical minimum for rain-fed agriculture on the scale required to support a city is probably about 300-400mm per year. At these levels barley, rather than wheat, provides the most reliable grain crop. Typically in this type of climate all the rain that is going to fall and enable the crops to grow comes over the winter months. A farmer's job is to capture as much as possible, for example by frequent ploughing that breaks up the soil and helps it trap moisture, or by terracing slopes. If the rains don't come at all during the winter months the farmer already knows well before harvest time that it's going to be a bad year. At this point people are going to be looking into how much they have stored up to see them through for this kind of situation, whether they have the means to import food, whether a quick spring-sown crop might stand any chance – or whether to take up arms or put to sea to go and grab what you need by violence. Bad years are quite common, people are used to dealing with them. But when bad years happen in consecutive years, which might be once in every couple of generations, or once in a century, total disaster can follow.

Land Quality

Some regions are more blessed than others for rains and especially rich soils that lead to higher yields, and even within a given region the particular situation of a plot of land, whether it catches the best of the rains or receives the most hours of sunshine, can affect how good is the

crop. A particularly good patch of land will be more expensive to buy, but on a normal success will generate an additional yield (e.g. 8x rather than 6x seed), and on a Critical Success will generate 10x. Land that's not suited to being ploughed and planted has its uses, and can actually be quite productive. This will include forestry, not just for timber and firewood but also for harvesting nuts, berries, fungi, herbs and fruit as well as for hunting; coastlines, rivers, streams and lakes yield fish, wetlands offer good hunting for wild fowl, possibly useful grasses and reeds; hillsides that are too steep for ploughing but if cleared may suit vines very well. All these things provide the citizens with the means to live beyond subsistence. They can also be really important for a wide range of crafts most of whom will be concentrated at the city itself.

Farms

A typical farm for an ordinary citizen might be 5 Hectares (approx. 12.5 Acres). But the poorest landowners have to make do with a lot less. Maybe only half a hectare, which a single person can just about subsist on. With a plot that small a farmer will need to find additional sources of income or pay, and has no chance of supporting a spouse, let alone children. Very often this is how the state, or the rich, like things to be. It means the poor have something to call their own, but also are dependent on hand outs, employment and loans from their social superiors to make ends meet. These are all opportunities to create loyal dependents, recruits for the army, and labour for the construction of public works or the estates of the wealthy. If however things become *too* exploitative, at some point the poor (who are also by definition "the many") get angry, agitate, riot and rebel, so there is a balance to strike.

Labour

A very small plot may be farmed with hand tools, but if you have even a 5 Hectare farm you will need access to a pair of oxen and a

ploughshare. Larger farms will have their own, smaller ones will rent, share or borrow as they can. If your farm is bigger than 8-10 Hectares you probably need not just access to a plough but also more human labour than your immediate household can manage, so that means bringing in some casual labour at busy times, or perhaps increasing your household by adding a slave or two.

An affluent citizen, the Gentry, is likely to have a farm at least 15 hectares or larger in size, with their own ox teams and ploughs, and unless blessed with a large extended family to share the work they are likely to have slaves to provide the labour required. If not employing family or owning slaves, someone with a larger farm could always lease out their land. But paying the maintenance cost of a slave and keeping all the produce will work out more profitable in the long run than talking a minority of a farm's produce, or a fixed rent.

If profiting from the work of enslaved people is not to your taste – or you don't like the capital investment required - you can try and find tenants to work your land. Renting out is popular because although it delivers less return it requires no capital outlay on slaves, and the tenants are also expected to join your gang of supporters. A typical rent would be between 15% and 20% of the tenants' produce.

If, like any rich person in a quasi-ancient world who has extensive landed estates and a claim to respectability, then you will need a team of people to work your land who have no option but to do as they are told. Buying slaves to work your farm is expensive at start-up, but more profitable in the long run than taking a rent from tenants. An agricultural slave costs 300-450SP, but immediately after a war slaves might be available cheaply, so that can be a good time to retire to the country life. Or, like the Spartans and their helots, you can leave a conquered people where they are and just take title over their land and everything produced from it. You don't need to look for tenants.

Farm Table					
Social Class	Typical Farm Size (Hectares)	Typical Product (SP)	Minimum Labour (Persons)	Estate Value or Purchase Price (SP)	Notes
Poor	2	125	0.5	1,000	A small patch of land tilled by hand, a poor family usually has no livestock, fallow land may be used for a supplementary crop, and perhaps a little garden. Just a one roomed house or shack on the land.
Yeoman	5	375	1	3,000	A farm of which half is arable, the rest being marginal land with a little garden and space for pigs and goats. Includes a cottage and rudimentary shelter for livestock. The farmer may have plough and oxen, but in any event these will be rented and borrowed between neighbours
Gentry	15	1,200	2	12,000	A farm suitable for an affluent citizen family, of which more than half is arable, and with enough room to pasture a small herd of cows or a flock of sheep. The farm has its own plough oxen. Includes a house, probably with multiple rooms and courtyard, a barn or byre.
Rich	50	3,500	7	30,000	A significant parcel of land of which at least half is arable but which may specialise with orchards, additional pasturage, grain, market garden, a small vineyard and other resources. Includes a house and additional cottages, out-buildings and shelters, granary etc
Magnate	400	30,000	50	300,000	A very large property with diverse resources covering everything from arable to pasture, vineyards and fishponds, but the majority of its activity specialised and geared to the market. Accommodation includes a fine villa, multiple outbuildings, cottages for tenants, and almost certainly a slave barracks.

We can assume if 8 hectares is the maximum a single person can work, then your farm needs a minimum labour force of one adult, slave or

serf per 8 hectares or part thereof, plus one. You do need to maintain your slaves and serfs, and it's up to you what standard of living you allow them, using the Adventurer Lifestyle Table as a

guide, and bearing in mind that serfs often come with families, requiring the x2.5 multiplier, but are self-sustaining. In effect they are tenants, but they are not entitled to up sticks and try some other way to make a living, instead being tied to the land the live and work on.

Example:

Hecateus is a gentleman farmer of Vestrikina in Korantia, with a 15-Hectare farm that can generate 1,200 SP worth of produce. His wife died in childbirth, his only son is still very young. With such a small family he needs only to make 750 SP per year² to maintain the Gentry lifestyle, which means his farm will generate a surplus of 450SP. That is enough to maintain two slaves who work the farm, and enable Hecateus not to have to do any labour himself. However this is not Hecateus' way. He brings in a female slave to run his house and care for his little son, and a slave to work alongside him on the farm. With outgoings of $750 + 144 + 144 = 1048$ SP the farm should still generate enough profit (152SP annually) to gradually recover the cost of purchasing the slaves, assuming he doesn't also spend too much each year on additional casual labour, or meeting one-off costs like replacing an aged plough-ox. When his son grows up and can take on the farm, Hecateus hopes to be able to retire to a life of leisure.

Hecateus's neighbour Solara has a similar size estate. Her husband was recently lost in a border skirmish with the Borissans, and so she has decided to divide her land into three plots of roughly equal size. She farms one herself with the help of her 3 adolescent children (generating 375 SP) and takes a rent from the other two. She can make perhaps a 6th of each tenant's produce as rent – in this case 125SP total. That gives Solara a total income of 600SP. Hecateus and Solara have both been passed by the city's census as having sufficient

land and produce to be counted among citizens of the 3rd census class in Vestrikina³ with the rights and privileges that entails, but while Hecateus lives a Gentry lifestyle, Solara has extra mouths to feed and is limited to the lifestyle of a Yeoman, unable to afford many of the luxuries that others in her wealth class enjoy.

The solution, to Hecateus, is obvious. Widower and widow should marry, and join their estates, creating a single unit with 30 Hectares, a couple of slaves, their own plough oxen, generating 2,400 SP worth of produce, and with enough land to also consider improvements, such as terracing or planting a vineyard. Also on his mind is that with a little bit of improvement works, and a friendly official running the census, their joint estates could valued at 25,000 SP. Under Vestrikina's law codes this would qualify Hecateus as a member of the Propertied Class, and he would be enrolled in the voting tribe called 'The Lions'. He would then be entitled to initiation into the cult of the Ruler God, Anayo, consort to the Queen of Heaven – and that brings with it a chance to take a seat on the city council.

Solara is not so sure, thinking of what will happen to her household's property when it is time to pass on to the next generation. Solara suspects that once Hecateus has created a much larger estate he will try to ensure that his son will one day inherit the lions' share of it all, leaving her own children downgraded or forced to go out in search of their own fortune...

Cash Crops

Once your subsistence needs are covered you can begin to think of your farm as a commercial enterprise. The simplest way to reflect that as part of the economics of your game is to continue to use grain as an abstract for all of a farm's productivity and the value of its output,

² Given there si only one child and one adult, a reduction to the Family and household multiplier from x2 to x1.5 seems fair

³ Corresponding to 'Middling' on the Shores of Korantia Social Class Table (SoK p39)

even if in reality the farmer is managing risk and grabbing opportunity by switching between wheat and barley, vegetables and legumes and actually maintaining quite a diverse range of crops. The farmer is also likely to use marginal land for fruit trees (especially olives), keeping beehives, or letting a few goats roam about that are used for milk and eventually for meat.

In a quasi-ancient world there is also constant demand for wine and oil. Producing either requires long-term investment – for example it takes at least five years from planting a vineyard to being able to harvest from it. But then it produces year after year, with no fallowing. A Hectare of vineyard can produce about 3,000 Litres of wine. Let's assume the processing of the grapes, fermentation storage etc accounts for half the retail value, that's still worth 300-600 SP even for the basic stuff.

Establishing a vineyard feels like a good place to start thinking about using the Manufacturing and Quality rules in the Mythras CRB. If the task of Establishing the Vineyard gains one enhancement, then it will henceforth produce Good wine as Standard, and if it gains two enhancements, it will produce Fine wine. An Acceptable outcome will result in a vineyard of which the wines can be sold at the upper end of the Basic Wine price range. Flawed or Poor result will downgrade the quality of the wine that can be reduced – and the price that it can command accordingly.

Using Mythras Rules to run a Farm

Judging by the Careers chapter in the CRB, the key skills for a farmer are Lore: Agriculture and Lore: Animal Husbandry. So it's about know-how more than how-to.

Lore (Agriculture). The basic professional knowledge of the arable farmer, who understands the routines the agricultural year for the crops suitable to their land, and the tasks

to be done with ploughing, planting, reaping and threshing. Someone with this skill can see when the soil would be better put under barley than wheat, or when the crop is failing and a quick second planting may be needed to rescue the year. This skill should be sufficient to run a farm that mixes grain, grape, orchards and a little livestock, but a grade of difficulty should apply if the farmer is managing a specialised facility outside the core such as a livestock ranch.

Lore (Animal Husbandry). While the huge flocks belonging to rich magnates are tended by professional shepherds who will move with the flocks between upland and lowland pastures as the seasons turn, many arable farmers have a few goats, sheep or pigs, some have oxen to take care of. The way they keep and use their animals is intrinsically linked to how they manage the wider farm, so the Lore (Agriculture) skill can still apply. Now and again the chance to call upon someone who has Lore (Animal Husbandry) is likely to provide a useful Augment to an Agriculture role when animals are used either as muscle-power or as a sideline.

Like any gaming situation, dice rolls should only be called for if there is a challenge and something meaningful at stake. Having enough to eat or money to live off is by most measures a high stakes situation! Somebody who knows Lore (Agriculture) should be able to work their farm and produce a crop under normal circumstances, and the moment a dice roll is called for a significant chance of failure is introduced⁴. So achieving a normal return from a farm should be an Easy roll. Failure results in a slight loss of productivity, only a Fumble will result in a disaster where the farm's output is slashed by 50%. Conditions outside the farmer's control will affect the difficulty grade:

⁴ Under Adventurer Creation rules the *maximum* Lore (Agriculture) skill for a starting Farmer character with average Intelligence is 71%.

- The field was not left fallow the previous year – One grade harder
- The rains have been lower than expected – Two grades harder
- There has been a drought (almost no rains) – Three grades harder

If an Adventurer is not a hands-on farmer but living off the rents from tenant farmers, then they should receive the specified rent, which is a proportion of the yield rather than a fixed amount. You may want to ensure that your Adventurer finds tenants who do know something about farming and bear the consequences if not. Alternatively, to introduce some variability without dice-rolling the annual productivity using the tenants' skills you can choose to use the Seasonal Income Table (CRB p54) to modify the income expected from the Adventurer's landholding.

Looking at the range of other skills available to the farmer that could have a bearing on how successful is their work, the following look promising as potential Augments to a Lore (Agriculture) skill roll. Or vice versa.

Athletics, Brawn, Endurance A lot of farming work involves strenuous physical activity, and if you don't have additional labour or animal muscle power to draw on, it can take a heavy toll. Athletics could be used for ploughing, reaping, winnowing and threshing, augmenting the Agriculture skill of another character. Brawn can help where heavy labour is needed, like clearing rocks from a field, loading and unloading produce. Endurance represents the physical stamina involved in many agricultural tasks – a tireless worker is a very valuable one.

Commerce. A farmer needs to know when the price of seed-corn is soaring or the value of their own crop is plummeting, and Commerce can help. Deciding whether to hold your grain in store waiting on an expected price hike over the winter, to specialise, to invest in new crops or new fields, to plant a vineyard, or turn a field over to pasture can all be looked at from a

Commerce perspective, and haggling for the best deal for the little bit of spare produce you have can make all the difference,

Craft (Winemaking). If you have a vineyard, then the services of an expert in producing wine will potentially add volume or quality to the product, and perhaps with this skill or a Lore (Winemaking) provide specialist knowledge of how to cope with a bad turn in the climate and conditions.

Engineering. Less obvious, but if you want to make changes that will transform the potential of your land, perhaps to terrace a hillside, drain a marsh or lake, divert a stream or river or construct a mill on your land at scale, Engineering skill is your friend. In a truly quasi-ancient society Engineering options are limited by technologies. There are no windmills, but watermills appear in Late Classical and Imperial Worlds, but ways to capture precious water, or get rid of it when there's too much by drainage projects are always of interest. Engineering may help you get at resources that are otherwise hard to access – so if your land has potential for quarrying or mining, this skill could be instrumental in releasing that potential.

Locale. This skill is all about where and when to do your planting to the best effect – a knowledge of where the soils are right for the crops and retain as much moisture as possible through the year, which side of a hill or valley tends to get the best rain or be sheltered from the worst of the winds; where there are neighbours with better access to wells or a stream they may share with you, and where you will find yourself blocked. Where you might benefit from proximity to a nearby temple or holy place, or a friendly nature spirit. Locale could be used to identify what land to buy, and what to lease or leave to nature.

The Agricultural Year as a Task

The Mythras 'Task Rules' found under the Equipment Manufacturing and Quality rules

(CRB p65). Could be applied to the business of managing a farm over a year. Because the agricultural year is a ticking clock there are a limited number of rolls that can be made to attempt to reach the total required for success.

The normal allocation is 4 rolls – you may want to imagine these as ploughing (preparing the soil), sowing the seed corn, reaping, threshing and winnowing. Even an adventurer with a career background as a farmer is more likely than not to fail one out of the four rolls. This is where augments come in. A local elder or family connection who provides sage advice with their Locale skill of how best to sow; a burly farmhand who helps with the harvest for a few meals and a few Silver Pieces, adding

FARMING TASK RESULTS TABLE	
Final Task Score	Result
150%	Crop yields increased, farm produces additional 50%
125%	Crop yields increased, farm produces additional 25%
100%	The farm's normal yield is achieved
75%	Crop yields reduced, farm produces 25% less
50%	Crop yields reduced, farm produces 33% less
25%	Crop yields reduced, farm produces 50% less
0%	The farm produces nothing usable this year

their Brawn to the plough or Athleticism to the threshing.

DISCUSSION



So far we have been looking at how to force a load of bits of factual information into a shape that will serve as a framework for an ancient style fantasy setting. What we have been ignoring all the way along is the fantasy part – and in the end that's what we come to a Fantasy Role Playing Game for. For now we'll put sorcery aside and focus on Theism, the magical path of calling on divine help to bring fortune and avert disaster, as it can be applied to whole communities.

If Gods are Real

Ancient people spent a lot of time and resources worshipping the gods, building temples,

sacrificing animals (and sometimes people). They mostly took the view that the gods are real and can genuinely help and hinder not only you as an individual but the whole family, community or city. And even if you are not entirely convinced, better safe than sorry. So we don't have to make any serious changes to the way people generally behave towards the gods simply because they *are* real. In your fantasy setting anything that happens at the whim of the gods may by default happen at about the same frequency as in the real world when caused by entirely natural forces. But the Adventurers and other inhabitants of the world now have some agency as they quest to appease or challenge a god and its human followers to secure the right

outcome. This much is pretty standard stuff. But when we look at the magic placed in the hands of the gods' followers, we should consider the effect of magic as a technology on how your world operates and society responds. Let's start with the ones who have the biggest effect on the largest number of people.

The Grain Goddess

Let's take a look at the Mythras Theist Miracle, *Bless Crops*. This Acolyte-level miracle is perhaps the least spectacular on the list. Its effects are to ensure the normal happens: that a field will bear fruit as expected and be protected to some degree from magical attack. Its area is 'tens of meters' which is slightly unhelpfully the *radius* of an area to be affected and so involves a fiddly calculation. But we can see that a follower of the fertility Goddess with a Devotion of 71-80% can call upon an Intensity 8 miracle that affects almost exactly 2 Hectares of land. Conveniently, with an 8-month duration, it also covers the entire growing cycle of most crops. The downside is that a typical Acolyte will have a Devotional Pool of no more than 6 Magic Points, and as an Acolyte level miracle costs two per casting, they can Bless up to 6 Hectares of arable land before needing to replenish their Devotional Pool. But as the Acolytes cannot replenish points that are committed to long duration Miracles, those 6 blessed hectares are pretty much 'job done' for the agricultural year. Of course they don't need to bless fields that are lying fallow, so returning to our average productivity rates, we can assume that each Acolyte is the insurance policy for next year's seed corn plus enough food to keep up to 16 people alive for a year. Pretty good going – but it doesn't scale well. To cover enough fields to feed a smallish city state of 5,000 people would require the work of over 300 Acolytes spending their divine favours on nothing else. So some logical social effects of worshipping the local Grain Goddess so that you can access her blessings on the crops on which your people depends could be:



- Society requires by law or custom that a significant section of the population, say all women of a specific age class (to mirror a how menfolk are often allocated for military service), must play an active part in the Grain Goddess cult that underpins the food supply, creating a large pool of Acolytes, perhaps enough to give near universal coverage at each year's planting festivals.
- Every agricultural settlement of any size has a temple or shrine, and the temple has its own lands. The Acolytes and Priests need only be enough to bless these temple fields, and their product is used to support the temple and to fill the community grain stores that will provide back-up if the wider harvests fail across the district.
- Only those in specific social classes have access to the service of the priesthood with their Bless Crops miracles. This could be the poor, to ensure they do not fall into debt or dependency on the rich; or it could be the rich, because they paid for the temple and are obliged to keep the community safe from other threats for which they need their crops to do well enough to maintain their riches.

If you want to get down into some real detail, reliance on Bless Crops will push people to keep fields together in one place rather than have little plots dotted around the landscape as is common in many peasant societies. Otherwise large parts of the miracle's Area of Effect may fall on stony ground, or on a neighbour you don't like. The effect may be to encourage inheritance of land by only one child so as not to fragment an estate, forcing any others to find their own living elsewhere; or that some lands cannot be bought or sold in anything other than specific size lots; or that the state owns all the land and allots it to citizens as a way of keeping each parcel of land from breaking up.

Bless Crops specifically works on preventing bad stuff happening to the growing crops. It doesn't deal with the problem of crops not growing at all because the rains have failed. It is impossible to understate the importance of the rains arriving each year to make it possible to produce a crop. And for that bit of divine providence we need to turn to the deity who is usually given the role of *King of the Gods*.

The Weather God

Cloud Call is an Acolyte-level miracle with an Area of Effect measured in kilometres. Since an Acolyte is expected to have at least 70% in key cult skill and we should assume one of those is likely to be Devotion (Weather God), an Intensity 8 *Cloud Call* miracle will enable an Acolyte to produce Moderate Rain over an area of approximately 200 square kilometres. Moderate Rain defined in Mythras as 2.5-10mm per hour. Looking across at real world figures, 5mm per hour would be about right for Moderate rain, and we don't want heavy downpours to wash away precious topsoil. So each use of the miracle by an Acolyte will generate about 40mm of rain across its Area of Effect over an 8-hour Duration. An Acolyte who can draw on this Miracle three times can therefore cover some 600 square km of terrain,

more than enough to cover the entire land area controlled by most city states. Even so, as Duration ends when the rain stops can in theory now refill their Devotional Pool and do it again. To be clear, 40mm or more of rain is enough to make a material difference to survival and prosperity. The average *annual* rainfall on some ancient city-states that depended on agriculture might be as low as 400mm. This is very close to a threshold for viable rain-fed agriculture, and so the priests of the Weather God could in fact wield awesome power to make or break a city.

Looking at *Cloud Call* I would suggest that, to ensure a good year's harvest, rainfall needs to be called upon across the whole territory – after all, what happens to the life-giving waters when they hit the ground is about topography, geology, evaporation rates, tree cover, the extent of artificial terracing – so many factors that we have to look at *Cloud Call*'s effect as being indirect and unpredictable. If a city relies on rivers and irrigation the rain may be needed hundreds of miles from where it will eventually be used. For example, if you lie on the Nile valley, the rains that sustain your crops fall hundreds of kilometres away in the Central African Highlands, where overspilling lakes will eventually feed the Nile, producing the near miraculous floods along the riverbanks that fertilise the land with rich soil some months later.



Some implications of Cloud Call could be:

- The Weather God's temple is the grandest temple in the city, his annual festival involves significant sacrifices used to fill the Devotional Pool of his Priests and Acolytes, and all citizens of a certain rank or wealth must bring prize animals worthy enough to please the God to the capital for slaughter. Once this is done the rituals for the Cloud Call miracle can begin.
- The Weather God's priests do not need to be many in number, but their role is prestigious and vital to the whole city's fortunes – perhaps only those of a certain blood line or rank are entitled to serve. It may be only the aristocrat given the (entirely honorary and ritual) title of Sacred King can call upon the Cloud Call miracle. In some places an ancient ritual may endure that involves the king's own death, or that of a surrogate; perhaps it is this ancient blood rite that ensures a single exhortation of the miracle will encompass the whole land, or guarantee the minimum annual rainfall required.
- The Weather God is also a War God. While he brings the rains to the city's lands, he can be called upon to deny them to the city's enemies. Between the winter rains and summer harvest, his lay followers and initiates use the time to swap their farming tools for spear and shield and fight their way to a place where their priest can perform a ritual which will reduce the rainfall in an enemy city's domain
- The rivers that feed the city's agriculture flow from distant uplands beyond the city's borders. If an enemy or hostile tribe occupies those lands and finds the means to turn the rains on and off, the whole city is in peril!
- The *Clear Skies* miracle – whether in your world that is a gift of the Weather God or the Sun God – could be a potent, even genocidal, weapon in the wrong hands if used to prevent vital rainfall. However it can be used to banish clouds that threaten to dump too much rain on crops before they can be harvested, causing them to rot in the ground, or for example to prevent the massive damage a hailstorm can inflict on orchards and vineyards.

Other Miracles That Can Change the World

In *Shores of Korantia* there are additional theistic miracles that provide help to the life-or-death business of producing food. These are not punchy adventuring spells – but they can be immensely, world-changingly powerful:

Boundary

Rank: Varies, Area of Effect: Special, Duration: Years

With this miracle the worshipper sets the boundary of an area of land in a way that is endorsed by divine providence and fully recognised under the city's laws. The land must be a single parcel of territory encompassed by an unbroken line that may pass through water only as deep as a man may wade through. The miracle can be made at different levels depending on the rank of the worshipper. The area is marked out with boundary stones by the caster, or perhaps by ploughing a furrow. The line of the boundary cannot intersect with a pre-existing boundary, although it can be contiguous.

The Area of effect is measured in hectares for an Initiate (1 Point Miracle) so as to encompass a farm, and in Square KM for an Acolyte (2 Point Miracle) so as to encompass the lands of a whole farming community, or perhaps the footprint of the city itself. A Priest (3 Point Miracle) can affect an area of up to 3 Square KM for every 100 Citizens enrolled on the census and in doing so he marks out the whole domain of the city.

The principle effect of this miracle is to redefine the Area of Effect to which other magic can be applied. Only miracles provided by Torthil himself or by allied cults may be affected. Bless Crops, Burn Fields, Fortify and Restore Earth* are compatible with this Miracle.

*A miracle provided by the goddess Sheylo which restores the fields after harvest so there is no need for fallowing

Boundary can have quite profound effects on your setting and should be seen as a significant ritual undertaking. Combined with Restore Earth (not universally available in Korantia, only in those cities founded by mutual agreement with the indigenous Thennalts), it can significantly reduce the arable area required for a city to achieve self-sufficiency. This has implications for where and how a city can exist, and how big it can get. But with some minor modifications it could form a core part of how your setting works. For example, if only a specific priest is able to cast the spell, and it lasts so long as he is alive, and his successor must recreate the magic for the good of the city. Or if it in fact can last beyond a lifetime, and must be renewed once every century, but in the meantime conflict or changes to the city's population has made the existing measures somehow inadequate or obsolete. If used to mark out the whole domain of a city, whether that's a new foundation or a city that has existed for many generations, boundaries can be challenged, or disputed.

Burn Fields

Rank Initiate, Area of Effect: Hectares

This miracle can be used to clear land or burn stubble after the harvest. However if used maliciously or as part of a scorched earth policy it can also torch food-bearing plants within the area of effect, which is equal to one hectare per point of Magnitude, destroying any possible harvest this year. The crops affected must be in contiguous fields, as the area of effect flows out from the caster like a flood of fire and if it meets a gap of uncultivated land more than 3 metres wide it is stopped and must expend its energy in other directions. Living creatures within the

burning zone are affected as if in contact with a small fire (1d6 damage per round, Evade test to avoid damage each round), and if not burned may find themselves suffering from asphyxiation by the smoke.

Burn Fields is a Miracle that would feature in a scenario where enemy raiders make the livelihoods of their victims the target of their attack – not the people themselves. It's a much more efficient, and so dangerous, way to do damage of this kind than attempting to trample crops, burn cottages or cut down orchards. And just what the local militia is supposed to be called out to deal with.

Folk Magic

The Mythras rules already offers Folk Magic spells that perhaps have more obvious utility in the everyday life of a quasi-ancient farmer than for an Adventurer. Alarm, Appraise, Beastcall, Bladesharp, Bludgeon, Calculate, Dry, Extinguish, Find (x), Glue, Heal, Ignite, Might, Preserve, Repair, Vigour, Warmth all have a claim to be part of a farmer's magical toolkit.

AFTERWORD

If you have made it this far I hope you have enjoyed these essays and found some useful ideas to play with. The point is not to try and set out a 'right way' to do quasi-ancient world-building or roleplaying, but to package up some thoughts, ideas and information that help you immerse yourself in and imagine your way around an ancient setting. We are here for fun. Fantasy doesn't have to keep to the realities of living in a real world past where life is tough and often short, slavery is 'normal', the patriarchy is unassailably in charge and the bar for what counts as brutality or atrocity is far, far higher. Much like a lot of human history, the ancient world is full of horrors as well as wonders, and these are far more 'in your face' if you are roleplaying rather than reading a history book. Nothing here says you can't pick or choose which features of past lives remain part of your quasi-ancient world. But I hope it will give you some tools in how you do that.